

HOUSES AND HOMES

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EVERYONE NEEDS A HOME, to provide comfort and shelter from the weather. It usually takes the form of a permanent house, although some people live in temporary structures, such as tents. Houses differ greatly around the world. They vary in what they are made of, because builders usually use local materials; in their structure, because their features must cope with local weather; and their plan. But they all provide a place for the inhabitants to sleep, eat, and cook.



Overhanging thatched roof keeps off rain and provides shade.

Wooden poles support roof.



Brick from local mud



Straw woven into matting

Early houses

From the earliest times, people built their houses out of materials that were available locally. Houses such as this African example have been made for thousands of years and are still built today. A wall of mud bricks is covered by a thatched roof supported on wooden pillars.

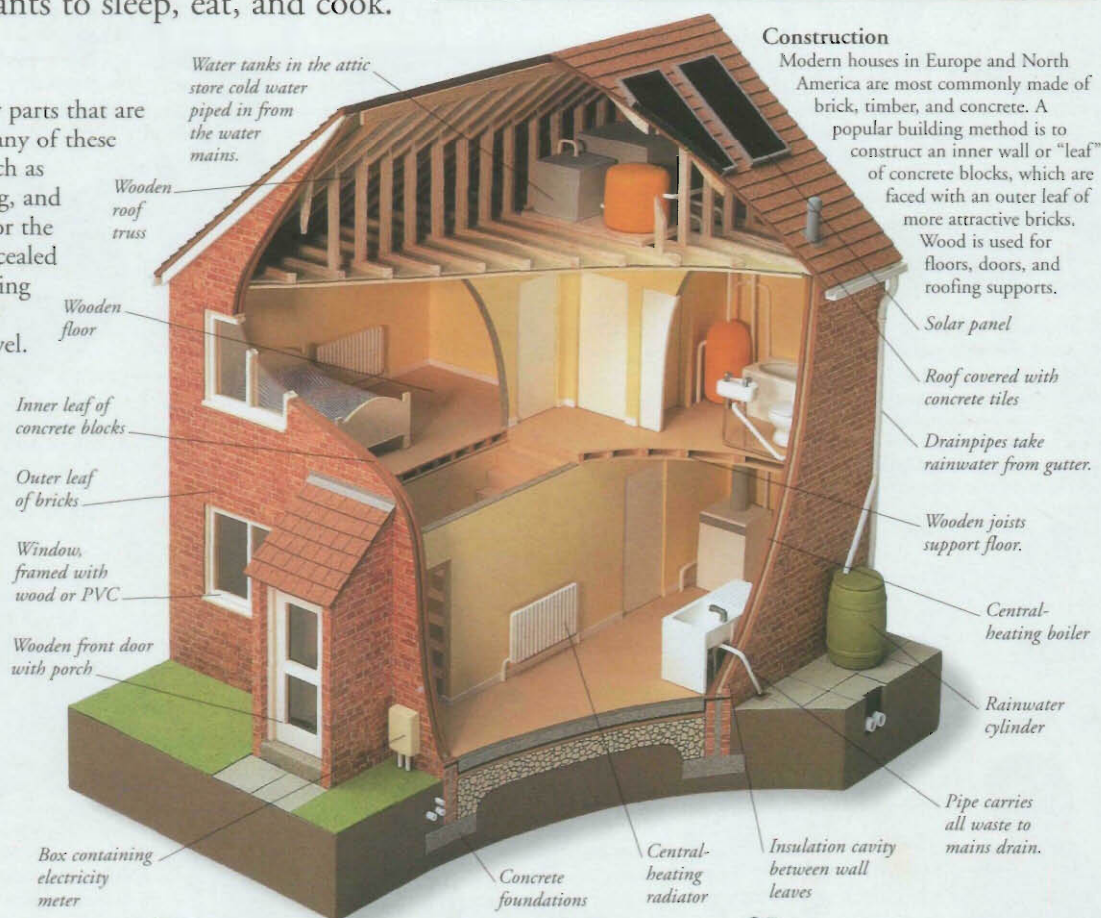
Inside a house

A modern house includes many parts that are normally hidden from view. Many of these are to do with the services – such as running water, drainage, heating, and electricity – that are provided for the occupants. Water tanks are concealed in the roof space, pipes and wiring are hidden behind plaster, and drains are dug below ground level.



Japanese house

Traditional Japanese houses have a timber framework. The gaps between the timber uprights are filled with wooden panels or sheets of paper to let through some sunlight. The rooms are designed to be covered by a set number of standard-sized straw mats called tatami mats.



Construction

Modern houses in Europe and North America are most commonly made of brick, timber, and concrete. A popular building method is to construct an inner wall or "leaf" of concrete blocks, which are faced with an outer leaf of more attractive bricks. Wood is used for floors, doors, and roofing supports.

Solar panel

Roof covered with concrete tiles

Drainpipes take rainwater from gutter.

Wooden joists support floor.

Central-heating boiler

Rainwater cylinder

Pipe carries all waste to mains drain.

Insulation cavity between wall leaves

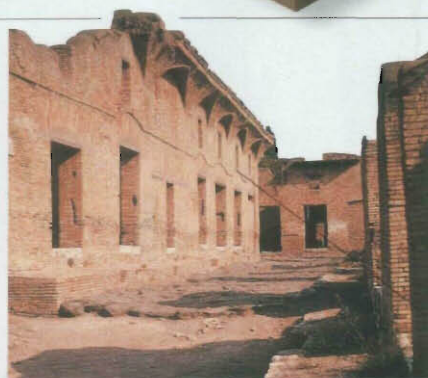
Central-heating radiator

Concrete foundations

Box containing electricity meter

Flats and apartments

In towns and cities, where space is limited and many people want to live near the centre, the answer is often to build upward, creating blocks of flats. This type of home became common in the 19th century, when cities began to expand quickly, and new devices such as steam cranes made it easier to lift building materials high up.



Roman apartments

The ancient Romans were the first to build blocks of apartments. In cities such as Rome and Ostia, rising ground rents and growing populations encouraged the trend, and many brick-and-concrete five- or six-storey apartment blocks were built.

In Ostia, the ancient Romans built flats above street-level shops.



Modern flats made of concrete and steel, in France

Modern apartments

From Paris to New York, apartment blocks are common in cities. Each apartment is linked to the ground by metal fire escapes to prevent residents from being trapped if there is a fire.

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